FROM THE

# EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

Gujarat has spoken, and so has Himachal Pradesh. Both in a manner that allows us to reach some significant conclusions for the Road to the 2024 general election. By wresting the highest seat tally that any party has ever registered in Gujarat, Prime Minister Narendra Modi has demonstrated that his brand still carries an unparalleled potency in Indian politics. The other plot elements are fascinating too. Although the Aam Aadmi Party opened its account in Gujarat with only single-digit seats, it garnered a double-digit vote share. It can take comfort in the fact that it is now certifiably a national party. The imploding Congress continued its self-willed extinction with its defeat in Gujarat but saved face by winning handsomely in Himachal Pradesh.

That stupendous 156/182 (as of December 8, 8.30 pm) is a remarkable figure: it has come after 27 years of incumbency, for about a decade of which Modi could not even tend directly to his home garden. He needed to stave off any disquiet on the ground, for Gujarat is not just any state. It is the one tied inextricably to the Modi narrative, and showing that it was impregnable was a crucial prerequisite for 2024. So, absolutely nothing was left to chance. Last year, the prime minister sacked the entire state cabinet, including the chief minister. And the BJP dropped 42 out of its 99 sitting MLAs during ticket distribution. Modi spent 13 days in Gujarat, addressed 31 rallies and conducted three road shows, including a grand 50-km-long cavalcade through Ahmedabad. High rhetoric flowed from his mic, neatly conflating Gujarati *asmita* with his persona in the slogan: 'I Made this Gujarat'. He willed the people to entrust their will to him again, and they complied. But Modi was framing this battle not merely with an eye on history—Madhavsinh Solanki's record or his own. Make no mistake. This was as much about tomorrow as yesterday. If he was willing to test the very durability of Brand Modi in the petri dish of elections, it's because this remains the BJP's magic lamp for 2024, and seeing how luminous it still burns is vital.



December 31, 2012



June 3, 2019

Five difficult state elections loom ahead just in 2023, and not every state is Gujarat. The challenges for the BJP will be self-evident. First up is Karnataka, where the Congress has a good chance of winning, if the response to Rahul Gandhi's Bharat Jodo Yatra is anything to go by. Also, the Bommai government has been stumbling from one controversy to another and is likely to face anti-incumbency. Then come the three heartland states of Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan—all of which the Congress famously won in 2018. In Chhattisgarh, Congress CM Bhupesh Baghel seems to be on the front foot after a five-year reign, although he faces internal division. He has no credible rival in the BJP. Former chief minister Raman Singh's brand seems to have faded away. In Madhya Pradesh, the BJP had wrested power again on the back of defections. However, there is weariness with the incumbent Shivraj Singh Chouhan, who has been chief minister since 2005, with a two-year interregnum after 2018. Therefore, former chief minister Kamal Nath fancies his chances again in the state. In Rajasthan, the BJP has been unable to settle on the various claimants for the chief ministership, particularly former chief minister Vasundhara Raje. But then, while incumbent Ashok Gehlot is no pushover, his rivalry with Pilot could be the Congress's undoing in Rajasthan. The BJP does stare at a weak state leadership in all three states—the natural corollary of exclusively relying on the Modi factor. The only positive it can lean on is that the somnolent Congress is also equally schism-ridden. Perhaps their win in Himachal will boost their morale and their disastrous performance in Gujarat and the MCD polls will spur them to put some oxygen back into their bloodstream. Then comes another away match in Telangana, where a newly-minted BJP state unit is up against a Goliath in KCR.

However, the three heartland states the BJP lost in 2018 exhibited a curious paradox: the party swept all but three out of their total 65 seats in the 2019 general election. But this was on the back of a black swan event: Modi's helmsmanship loomed over all else in such a manner after Pulwama/ Balakot that it enabled the NDA government to override severe economic headwinds. That mood carried over into the aftermath of 2019: the crucial state of Uttar Pradesh registered a stunning turnaround for the party in 2022 after a string of electoral setbacks, including in Jharkhand (2019) and West Bengal (2021). The flame was kept alive, at least for Gujarat.

But over and above the tough matches of 2023, the political dynamics in some major non-election-bound states cannot be predicted with any certainty. Maharashtra offers the BJP the chance to make ingress into its cash-rich local bodies next year, but overall, the state is in flux after the Shiv Sena split. Even more troublingly for the saffron party, equations have changed in Bihar after Nitish Kumar flipped back towards the secular mahagathbandhan. To sustain the impression Modi's BJP gives of being an unstoppable, elemental force, therefore, will be way tougher before 2024. In Uttar Pradesh, the BJP has a strong local leader in Yogi Adityanath, but there is a possibility of the Opposition parties getting together there.

How the ruling party manages the narrative on other fronts will be interesting to watch. The economy continues to be sluggish, with domestic and global agencies tapering down their India growth ratings for the next couple of years. Against a recessionary and conflict-ridden global scenario, it won't be easy to create miracles on the job front or tamp down conclusively on prices. By the time he seeks a renewed mandate, Modi would have completed a decade as India's prime minister. Anti-incumbency, much in evidence in Himachal and Delhi, cannot be kept from becoming a factor at the Centre indefinitely. That's why one can expect the 'grand narrative' themes like national security and Hindutva to be kept alive with the imminent inauguration of the Ram temple in Ayodhya and a sustained polarisation on issues like the Uniform Civil Code. Even in Gujarat, the split opposition vote was crucial in delivering its historic number of seats. But the BJP can be confident that Brand Modi is alive and kicking. Nationally, the extreme dependence on that brand, reminiscent of what Indira Gandhi represented for the Congress in another era, poses a challenge that the world's largest political party will need to encounter. But, for now, the BJP's gigantic organisational mind keeps ticking as it fixes a firm eye on the Road to 2024 while the Opposition parties remain in disarray.



*(Aroon Purie)*